FOR HIRING MANAGERS

Headcount Sanity Check

Printable checklist. Fill it in by hand before you ask for a new headcount.

Check one box per question, or write your answer on the lines. Each answer tells you which question to do next. When you finish, hand these pages to whoever reviews headcount requests. Nothing is sent anywhere.

STOP	Put the request down and do what the box says. Nothing is submitted. Start again from Q1 when it is done.
PAUSE	Do the task, then write a few sentences on what you did, who was involved, when, and what happened. Return to the same question and answer it again.
HEADS UP	You can stop, or continue with a written reason. Your approver will see that you continued.
Goes to your approver	Your answer is passed on as context. It never stops the request.
Proof	When you say you did something, write who you asked, when, and what happened.

Your name

_____

Date

_____

THE REQUEST

Q1 What kind of request is this?

☐ Replacing someone who left	Go to Q1a
☐ A new role that is not in the approved plan	Go to Q2
☐ Turning a contractor into an employee	Go to Q2

Q1a Is the role still needed as written?

Follow-up question

☐ Yes	Go to Q2
☐ It needs changes	Go to Q2
☐ Not sure	PAUSE: Check the role first

Q2 How long will the work last?

☐ Under 6 months	Go to Q2a
☐ 6 to 12 months	Go to Q3
☐ 12 months or more, ongoing	Go to Q3
☐ I don't know	PAUSE: Work out the timeline first

HEADS UP This may fit a contractor or vendor better

Work that ends within 6 months usually costs less and carries less risk as contractor or vendor work than as a permanent hire.

☐ Try that instead	STOP: Try a contractor or vendor
☐ I still need a full-time hire	Go to Q3

THE NEED

Q3 In your own words, what does a long-term need mean for this role, and why does this role meet it?

Goes to your approver

Your approver reads this to decide whether the demand will last. Be specific about what keeps the work coming.

Then: *Go to Q4*

Q4 Which goal does this hire move?

Pick the goal this hire moves most.

☐ Grow revenue	Go to Q4a
☐ Reduce costs	Go to Q4a
☐ Reduce risk or meet a legal requirement	Go to Q4a
☐ Keep customers	Go to Q4a
☐ Launch something new	Go to Q4a
☐ Keep current operations running	Go to Q4a
☐ None of these	STOP: Tie the request to a goal

Q4a How does this hire move that goal?

Follow-up question

Two to three sentences.

Then: *Go to Q5*

Q5 What breaks if you do not make this hire?

Describe what would stop, slow down, or go wrong.

Then: *Go to Q6*

Q6 How long has this need existed?

Goes to your approver

This never stops the form. It gives your approver context.

☐ Under 3 months	Go to Q6a
☐ 3 to 12 months	Go to Q6a
☐ 1 to 3 years	Go to Q6a
☐ More than 3 years	Go to Q6a

Q6a How has the team covered the work so far?

Follow-up question | Goes to your approver

Say who has been doing it and what has been left undone. If this is a new need, say how you would cover it while you hire.

Then: *Go to Q7*

Q7 Is the workload caused by a broken process, tool, or approval step? Could fixing it remove the need?

☐ Yes, fixing it could remove the need	STOP: Fix the process first
☐ Not sure	PAUSE: Look at the process first
☐ No	Go to Q7a

Q7a Why not? Show what you checked.

Follow-up question | Proof: say who, when, and what happened

What you checked

Who you asked

What you found

Then: *Go to Q8*

OTHER WAYS TO COVER THE WORK

Q8 List the tasks and duties this person would do.

One per line. The next questions check these against your current team.

Then: *Go to Q9*

Q9 Do any of these duties overlap with your own role or a current team member's?

☐ Yes	Go to Q9a
☐ No	Go to Q10
☐ Not sure	PAUSE: Check with other teams

Q9a Which tasks overlap, and with whom? Include your own role.

Follow-up question | Proof: say who, when, and what happened

Person or team (write me for your own role)

Overlapping tasks

Why that person can't take on more

Then: *Go to Q10*

Q10 How is the work divided across your current team?

Your approver reads this next to the team survey results.

☐ Evenly, and I check it regularly	Go to Q10a
☐ Mostly even, but I have not checked closely	PAUSE: Look at the workload first
☐ No, some people carry more	Go to Q10b
☐ I have not looked	PAUSE: Look at the workload first

Q10a How do you check workload, and what did you find?

Follow-up question | Proof: say who, when, and what happened

Name the tool, meeting, or numbers you use. For example hours, tasks per person, or time off.

How you check

Last time you checked (date)

What you found

Then: *Go to Q11*

Q10b Who carries more, and what have you done to rebalance?

Follow-up question | Proof: say who, when, and what happened

Then: *Go to Q11*

Q11 The committee will send an anonymous survey to your current team as part of this request. It will cover their current work-life balance, workload balancing, and fairness in work delegation. How do you feel about that?

Goes to your approver

We will share the survey results with you, though you will not see individual answers. You will see only aggregated responses. Your team's answers will be considered by the committee.

☐ That works for me	Go to Q12
☐ I have some concerns	Go to Q11a
☐ I would rather it did not happen	Go to Q11a

Q11a What are your concerns?

Follow-up question | Goes to your approver

Then: *Go to Q12*

Q12 Does another team need the same skills?

☐ Yes	PAUSE: Talk to that team
☐ No	Go to Q12a
☐ I don't know	PAUSE: Ask nearby teams

Q12a Who did you ask, when, and what happened?

Follow-up question | Proof: say who, when, and what happened

Who you asked

When (date)

What happened

Then: *Go to Q13*

Q13 Is anyone on your team or another team interested in learning and growing into this role?

☐ Yes	STOP: Talk to HR about a development plan
☐ No	Go to Q13a
☐ I don't know, or I have not asked	PAUSE: Ask your team first

Q13a Who did you ask, when, and what happened?

Follow-up question | Proof: say who, when, and what happened

Who you asked

When (date)

What happened

Then: *Go to Q14*

Q14 Have you posted the job internally?

☐ No, not posted	PAUSE: Post the job internally
☐ Yes, and someone is interested	STOP: Review the internal candidate first
☐ Yes, and no one applied or no one was qualified	Go to Q14a

Q14a Show the internal posting and what happened.

Follow-up question | Proof: say who, when, and what happened

Link to the posting

Dates it was open

What happened

Then: *Go to Q15*

Q15 Can AI or an automated tool do this job, fully or partly?

☐ Yes, mostly	STOP: Test automation first
☐ Partly	Go to Q15a
☐ No	Go to Q15b
☐ I am not sure	STOP: Find out first

Q15a Which part could it do, and what would still need a person?

Follow-up question

Then: *Go to Q15b*

Q15b Why or why not? Show what was tested.

Follow-up question | Proof: say who, when, and what happened

Why or why not

Who tested it (write none if no one)

When (write never if untested)

Result

Then: *Go to Q16*

Q16 What will this role get to decide?

Goes to your approver

Pick the highest level of decision-making this person will have on their own. HR or Compensation sets the final level.

☐ Manages money and people: sets budgets, assigns duties, hires, fires, and runs performance reviews	Go to Q16a
☐ Guides others and owns an area, with no direct reports: mentors, coaches, and makes the calls in their specialty	Go to Q16a
☐ Does assigned work and makes daily calls on how to do it, and checks in on bigger decisions	Go to Q16a
☐ Supports others with admin and coordination, and follows set procedures	Go to Q16a
☐ I am not sure	PAUSE: Talk to HR about the level

Q16a Give one example of a decision this person would make without asking you.

Follow-up question | Goes to your approver

Then: *Go to Q17*

Q17 Which other options have you tried?

Pick all that apply. You need at least two before you submit. Pick None yet if you have not tried any. If you pick Something else, you will name it on the next screen.

- [ ] Delayed or dropped lower-priority work
- [ ] Used a contractor or vendor
- [ ] Borrowed help from another team with bandwidth
- [ ] Used part-time or fractional help
- [ ] Used a temp or intern
- [ ] Moved someone off lower-priority work
- [ ] Something else
- [ ] None yet

Picked 2 or more: *Go to Q17a*. Picked fewer than 2, or None yet: *PAUSE: Try other options first*.

Q17a For each option you picked, show what happened.

Follow-up question | Proof: say who, when, and what happened

Name the something else you tried, in a few words (only if you picked "Something else")

Option 1: what you tried, who was involved, when, and the result

Option 2: the same details

Any other options: the same details (optional)

Then: *Go to Q18*

TIMING AND APPROVAL

Q18 Has your manager seen this request?

☐ Yes	Go to Q18a
☐ No	PAUSE: Show your manager first

Q18a What is your manager's name?

Follow-up question | Proof: say who, when, and what happened

Then: *Go to Q19*

Q19 When is it needed?

☐ Now, to hit this quarter's goal	Go to Q20
☐ It could wait one quarter	Go to Q19a
☐ It could wait longer	Go to Q19a

HEADS UP This could go in next quarter's batch

Reviewing every request together helps approvers compare them fairly.

☐ Hold for next quarter	STOP: Hold for next quarter
☐ Submit now	Go to Q19b

Q19b Why can't it wait?

Follow-up question

Then: *Go to Q20*

Q20 This is a hypothetical question. If opening this role meant giving up one of your current roles, would you still say yes?

Goes to your approver

This is only a thought exercise. No staff will be cut automatically if this headcount is approved. The question never stops the form. It shows your approver how you rank this role.

☐ Yes	Go to Q20a
☐ No	Go to Q20a
☐ Not sure	Go to Q20a

Q20a In that scenario, which work or role would you give up? If none, say why.

Follow-up question | Goes to your approver | Optional

Then: *Go to Q21*

ROLE DETAILS

Q21 Role details

Team

Job title

Desired start date (date)

Salary is left blank. HR or Compensation fills it in.

Then: *Finish. Go to the Sanity check page.*

BEFORE YOU HAND THIS IN

Sanity check

Read your answers once more, then check each box that is true. This does not predict approval. Your approver also looks at budget and plans, which this page does not have.

- ☐ Each written answer has names, dates, and numbers, not only general statements.
- ☐ Every proof question says who you asked, when, and what happened.
- ☐ No two questions have the same answer written in them.
- ☐ Anything you continued after a Heads up has a written reason.
- ☐ Your manager has seen this request.
- ☐ Salary is left blank. HR or Compensation fills it in.

All boxes checked: hand the pages in. **Any box empty:** strengthen those answers first.

What each STOP and PAUSE says

Type	Title	What to do
STOP	Try a contractor or vendor	If a contractor or vendor cannot do the work, start again and explain why. Nothing is submitted.
STOP	Tie the request to a goal	A new hire should move a business goal. Talk to your manager about which goal this role supports, then start again. Nothing is submitted.

Type	Title	What to do
STOP	Fix the process first	If fixing a process, tool, or approval step could remove the need, start there. Start again if the need remains. Nothing is submitted.
STOP	Talk to HR about a development plan	Someone interested in growing into this role may be your best hire. Talk to HR about a plan for that person. If they cannot be ready in time, start again and explain why. Nothing is submitted.
STOP	Review the internal candidate first	Someone has shown interest in this role. Review that candidate before you request a new hire. Start again if they are not a fit, and explain why. Nothing is submitted.
STOP	Test automation first	If an AI or automated tool can do most of this job, test it before you request a hire. Start again with the results. Nothing is submitted.
STOP	Find out first	Ask your IT or operations lead whether AI or automation could do some of this work. Start again with what you learn. Nothing is submitted.
STOP	Hold for next quarter	Submit this request with next quarter's batch so approvers can compare all requests together. Nothing is submitted.
PAUSE	Check the role first	Ask your manager whether the role should stay the same, change, or go away. Then return to Q1a and write at least a few sentences about what you did.
PAUSE	Work out the timeline first	Estimate how long this work will last. Ask your manager or look at the plan for the next year. Then return to Q2 and write at least a few sentences about what you did.
PAUSE	Look at the process first	Ask the people who do the work whether a process, tool, or approval step is the cause. A quick fix may remove the need. Then return to Q7 and write at least a few sentences about what you did.
PAUSE	Check with other teams	Ask your own team and other teams whether anyone already does these tasks. Then return to Q9 and write at least a few sentences about what you did.
PAUSE	Look at the workload first	Look at who does what across your team, plus overtime and time off. Then come back and describe what you found. Then return to Q10 and write at least a few sentences about what you did.
PAUSE	Talk to that team	If another team needs the same skills, one shared request may cover both. Talk to them, then come back. Then return to Q12 and write at least a few sentences about what you did.
PAUSE	Ask nearby teams	Ask nearby teams whether they need these skills, then come back. Then return to Q12 and write at least a few sentences about what you did.
PAUSE	Ask your team first	Ask your team and nearby teams whether anyone wants to grow into this role. Come back when you have asked. Then return to Q13 and write at least a few sentences about what you did.
PAUSE	Post the job internally	Post it inside the company first and give people time to apply. Come back with the results. Then return to Q14 and write at least a few sentences about what you did.
PAUSE	Talk to HR about the level	Ask HR or Compensation what level this role needs, then come back. Then return to Q16 and write at least a few sentences about what you did.
PAUSE	Try other options first	Try at least two of these options before you submit, then come back and tell us what happened. Then return to Q17 and write at least a few sentences about what you did.

Type	Title	What to do
PAUSE	Show your manager first	Your manager needs to see this request before you submit. Share it, then come back. Then return to Q18 and write at least a few sentences about what you did.